

Wave phonk is a fusion of phonk's hard-hitting trap elements (e.g. distorted 808s and cowbell leads) with wave music's atmospheric and emotional soundscapes. Producing this genre in FL Studio involves a blend of creative sound design, clever arrangement, and precise mixing/mastering. Below we dive into advanced techniques across sound design, arrangement, automation & layering, mixing/mastering, and the tools and practices favored by leading wave phonk producers. All tips are given in the context of FL Studio, emphasizing its stock plugins and workflow (without step-by-step instructions), and backed by insights from the wave phonk community and top artists.

## Sound Design Techniques in Wave Phonk

Wave phonk's signature sound comes from a dark, atmospheric palette combined with aggressive distorted tones. Here's how producers craft these sounds:

- **Phonk Cowbell Leads:** The iconic phonk cowbell lead (often a sampled cowbell) is typically pitched and detuned with multiple voices to create a tense, chorus-like effect. This heavy detune gives phonk its unique character and leaves little room for other melodic instruments playing at the same time (additional melodies often sound out of tune against it). In FL Studio, you can layer a cowbell sample in the Channel Rack with slight pitch variations or use a synth (e.g. 3xOSC or Vital) with unison voices to achieve this detuned multi-voice cowbell sound. Many producers simply find a good cowbell sample (there are countless on Splice/Loopcloud) and then tune it to the track's scale (phonk often uses dark scales like Phrygian dominant) before detuning/cloning it for thickness. Advanced tip: Some wave phonk artists layer a synthesized tone underneath the cowbell. For example, one might create a synth lead in Vital or Serum and layer it with the cowbell sample to reinforce the attack or add more body. Blending the synthetic layer with the sample can make the lead sound more unique while retaining the cowbell's character.

- **Atmospheric Pads and Textures:** A distinguishing feature of "wave" influence is the use of lush pads, ambient textures, and dark atmospheres. Producers like LXST CXNTURY rely on rich pad sounds to create an emotional backdrop. These pads are often simple in melody (sometimes just two alternating notes or a sustained chord) but drenched in effects. To achieve this in FL Studio, start with a mellow synth pad (stock plugins like Sytrus or Flex have useful pad presets, or use third-party synths) and add heavy reverb and filtering. It's common to low-pass filter pads or piano loops so they sit "under" the mix and sound dark and distant. Generous reverb (e.g. Fruity Reeverb 2 or Valhalla VintageVerb) gives an atmospheric "spacey" tail, while a low-pass filter or an EQ cut of high frequencies ensures the pad doesn't compete with the lead for brightness. These ambient elements often play during intros, breakdowns, or under drops to provide a dense background. Subtle background textures—like field recordings, noise, or even reversed

sounds—are also layered in. For example, LXST CXNTURY's tracks include things like "reversed cricket sounds, chimes, and barely audible open hats" to fill out the atmosphere . In FL Studio, you can import such foley samples and tuck them low in the mix with reverb to add depth.

- **Bass: 808s and Reese Bass:** Low end in wave phonk is critical. Many producers use the classic distorted 808 sub-bass hits from phonk/trap, but some favor a reese bass (a sustained, distorted synth bass) for a continuous growl. 808s in wave phonk are usually deep and heavily distorted, often hitting on every kick drum . A common technique is to hard-clip and saturate the 808 for maximal weight: for example, using Fruity Wave Shaper into a Fruity Limiter on the 808 channel to drive it into distortion and then ceiling it . This creates a fat, sustained 808 with crunchy harmonics. In practice, you'd increase the Wave Shaper curve to add distortion and use the Limiter to prevent excessive peaks, yielding a hard-clipped, aggressive bass . OTT multiband compression (Xfer's free OTT preset) is sometimes added after distortion to bring out the 808's details and grit . Just be mindful of sub frequencies: roll off the extreme low-end rumble (below ~30 Hz) to avoid muddiness and phase issues . On the other hand, some wave phonk tracks (especially those leaning more "wave") use a reese bass instead of an 808 . A reese bass is typically made by detuning two saw waves and adding distortion and filtering. Producers like LXST CXNTURY often have a "repeating plucking bass sound" or a droning bassline that drops into a heavy reese during the drop . In FL Studio, you can design a reese using Sytrus or Harmor: two or more oscillators slightly detuned, lowpassed, and distorted (Fruity Fast Distort or Wave Shaper work well). Sidechain the reese to the kick (more on sidechaining later) so that each kick hit creates that pumping effect. The choice between 808s and reese bass (or even combining both) will shape the feel of your track – 808s give that punchy TikTok "drift phonk" vibe, while a reese can sustain the low-end and add an ominous drone under the mix .

- **Melodic Synths and Plucks:** Aside from cowbells, wave phonk producers incorporate other synth leads or plucks, often with a trance or hardstyle influence (as noted by Skeler, who brings trance arpeggios into the wave genre ). These could be airy lead synths, nostalgic plucks, or even piano riffs. The key is to keep melodies simple and moody – a few notes that repeat or evolve gradually (nothing too complex or "happy"). When designing these sounds, producers make them "lo-fi" and dark: for example, applying iZotope Vinyl or RC-20 Retrocolor to a synth lead to degrade it can mimic the vintage feel . One producer notes a synth melody that "sounds very lo-fi... you can get that effect with iZotope Vinyl (free) or RC-20" . Delay and reverb are heavily used on synth leads to give a sense of space and nostalgia. In FL Studio, try Fruity Delay 3 on a ping-pong setting and Fruity Reverb 2 with a long decay to make a simple melody echo into the distance. Also consider distortion on melodic synths – wave phonk often blends beauty with grit. For instance, LXST CXNTURY's track "Havoc" has a synth melody with "a lot of distortion... plus delay and reverb" . You can use plugins like Fruity Fast Dist, Blood

Overdrive, or third-party saturators (Soundtoys Decapitator, etc.) to lightly crunch the top end of a lead, giving it an edgy texture that cuts through the pad ambience. Just EQ out any harsh resonances after distortion to keep it smooth.

- **Memphis Rap Vocals & Chops:** Wave phonk commonly features Memphis phonk vocal samples – those chopped or slowed rap lines from 90s Memphis hip-hop – to add an eerie, retro vibe. These samples are inherently lo-fi (many come from old tapes with vinyl crackle and noise) . To process vocals in this style, make them sound even more degraded and ghostly. Key techniques include: pitch shifting or formant shifting (using tools like NewTone, Elastique Pitch, or Little AlterBoy) to make alternate layers (one octave down for a demonic low voice, or up for a creepy chipmunk tone) ; EQing to telephone frequencies (cut out most lows and highs, emphasizing the midrange around 300–3k Hz) to mimic a “radio” or distant sound ; and adding distortion/bitcrush to reduce quality . One guide suggests creating multiple vocal layers with pitch shifting – for example, mixing a low octave and a high octave of the same vocal – to get that detuned, chaotic feel . These layers “sound ‘low quality’ on purpose” when combined . In FL, you might clone the vocal sample to two channels, use Fruity Pitcher or NewTone to shift one down an octave (or use Little AlterBoy if available for formant shifting) , and shift one up (or formant up) for texture. Then EQ each (or group) with Fruity Parametric EQ2, cutting out rumbling lows and hissy highs . Add a Fruity Distortion or bitcrusher (e.g. dBlue Crusher) to dirty them up. Finally, reverb is your friend here – typically phonk vocals are drenched in reverb so they sit “buried in the mix and unintelligible” . Use a large hall reverb (mix to taste) to make the vocal sound like it’s in a huge empty space. Pro tip: Sum the vocal to mono (you can use FL’s Stereo Shaper or a free plugin like A1StereoControl to ensure the vocal is mono) , which centers the vocal and gives you room to spread other elements in stereo. Also, sidechain the vocal to the kick and snare so that it ducks out when drums hit – this keeps the vocal from cluttering the impact of your beat.

- **Drums and Percussion:** The drum selection in wave phonk is a mix of trap and wave aesthetics. Kicks are often punchy and clean (trap-style 808 kicks or even house kicks if doing four-on-the-floor sections ), as they need to punch through heavy bass. Snares and claps range from typical trap snares to more vintage, lo-fi snares. Many producers avoid super high-pitched trap snares and opt for something “heavier” or more retro – e.g. “not generic trap snares, something more interesting, lo-fi and with reverb” . Layering a clap or rimshot with the snare is common to add character. For example, you might layer a phonk-y snare with a shorter clap, and even include a one-shot “reverb clap” that hits on accent beats for atmosphere . In FL, you can route the snare and clap layers to one mixer bus and apply unified processing (see Mixing section). Hi-hats in wave phonk can use drill/ trap patterns (fast 1/16 or 1/8 note rolls) or even simple house/ techno rhythms, depending on the track’s feel . A lot of phonk hats are very rapid and rolling. A notable trick is to pitch your hi-hats

down a bit – one observation is that LXST CXNTURY uses hats “in low pitch, that gives a lo-fi feel” . You can also layer multiple hats: for instance, a bright hat and another hat sample an octave lower to add weight . Percussion like open hats, crashes, and rides are used sparingly to fill space (e.g. a washy ride or crash behind the main hats to add wash). Don’t forget phonk percussion elements like the classic cowbell (covered above) and occasional gun cock or horse neigh samples as FX hits – common in drift phonk. These, however, should be used tastefully in wave phonk to not override the wavey mood. Finally, add some background FX: producers often sprinkle reverse cymbals, risers, impacts, or even “gang shouts” into their drum patterns to keep them lively . For example, reverse a clap or crash to lead into a snare hit for a swoosh effect.

## Arrangement Methods and Track Structure

Arranging a wave phonk track means balancing immersive atmospheric sections with high-energy drops. A typical structure often borrows from EDM/trap arrangements (intro – drop – breakdown – drop – outro), but with creative twists. Here are some arrangement methods and tips:

- **Typical Structure:** Many wave phonk songs follow an 8-bar section logic. For example, Kordhell’s “Murder in My Mind” (a popular drift phonk track) can be templated as: Short intro → 8-bar intro → 8-bar drop → 8-bar drop with vocals → 8-bar switch/chorus → 8-bar drop → 8-bar drop with vocals → short outro . This is essentially two drop cycles with a contrasting “chorus” in the middle. You don’t have to copy this exactly, but marking out sections in 8-bar (or 16-bar) chunks helps give the track an evolving structure . In FL Studio’s Playlist, it’s useful to set Time Markers (right-click the timeline) for “Intro,” “Drop 1,” “Breakdown/Switch,” “Drop 2,” etc., to plan your sections .

- **Intros and Atmosphere Building:** The intro is where you set the mood. Wave phonk intros are often ambient and cinematic, gradually introducing elements. You might start with just a pad and distant vocal sample, or some vinyl crackle and a filtered melody. A great trick for intros is to apply a lo-fi filter or vinyl effect to make it sound like an old recording. For example, using the free iZotope Vinyl plugin on the master or main sample can instantly give a nostalgic, degraded intro vibe . One producer did this to create a “lofi effect” in the intro before the drop . Gradual buildup: as you approach the drop, add risers, sweeps, and drum fills. Classic EDM uplifters (noise risers, pitch risers) work well, but wave phonk often favors a kick roll build-up – e.g. a fast repeating kick crescendo. The “classic kick roll” (rolling double-time kicks that speed up over a bar or two) is an effective way to build tension . In FL Studio, you can create a kick roll by shortening a kick sample’s length and programming 1/8, 1/16, 1/32 note patterns that accelerate. High-pass filtering your build-up (gradually cutting the bass frequencies of the whole mix or of the drums) is another way to create tension – it makes the drop hit harder when the bass comes back full force . Automate a

Fruity EQ2 on the master (or drum bus) to sweep out low frequencies in the last 4 bars before the drop, then release at drop impact.

- **Drop Sections:** The drop is where the full beat, bass, and lead all slam in. In wave phonk, a drop often consists of the detuned cowbell lead (or a distorted synth lead) + heavy 808/reese bass + full drums + vocal chops. To keep the energy up, many producers will introduce the main elements in the first drop and then add variation later. For example, you might have Drop 1 with just instrumental, and Drop 2 with the vocal sample added to elevate intensity. It's also common to have two-part drops (8 bars + 8 bars) where the second half introduces something new (like a more aggressive drum pattern or a new synth layer). Arrangement tip: Mute strategically for impact. A classic move is to cut all music briefly before a drop or major hit – e.g. have a one-beat pause (with maybe a reverb tail or a vocal shout) right before the drop, so when the drop hits, it hits hard. In "Murder in My Mind," they drop out everything except a vocal line right before the beat drops, which makes the impact stronger. You can do this in FL by slicing all clips a beat before the drop and muting that slice. Alternatively, automate the master volume to kill the sound briefly (just be careful with any tails).

- **"Switch" or Mid-track Breakdown:** Wave phonk often includes a contrasting section mid-track, sometimes referred to as a switch or chorus. This section (often after the first round of drops) gives the listener a new vibe before returning to the drop. Typically, you change the lead melody and/or the vocal to make a noticeable shift. For example, after a drop with the main cowbell riff, you might go into an 8-bar breakdown where the cowbell riff is replaced by a new melody or chord progression – changing the mood to something more melancholic or uplifting – effectively a "chorus" part. In this section, producers often layer pads, bring in new vocal chops, or play a variation of the lead an octave higher or lower. A simple but effective trick: take your main lead and pitch it up or down an octave when the second verse or vocal section hits. This maintains the continuity of the sound but instantly feels fresh to the ear. You could also alter the lead's rhythm or a few notes to distinguish this section. Sage (a wavephonk producer) emphasizes creating an atmosphere or vibe here that emotionally connects with the listener, rather than just trying to be loud or aggressive. So, often the switch section is slightly more chilled or emotional. You might drop the 808s out and use a flowing reese bass or sub bass here, or add a lush chord progression under the lead. Continuity: Even in a switch-up, keep some elements consistent so the track doesn't feel like a random new song. For instance, maintain the same drum groove or bass root notes. One guide suggests that during the switch/breakdown, you should at least keep the main drum groove and bass present, just with changes in melody/vocal, so the identity of the track remains. After this breakdown/chorus, the arrangement usually circles back to another high-energy drop (often a double-length final drop or a repeat of drop+vocal).

- **Outro:** The outro in wave phonk is usually short – often just a quick wind-down after the final drop, maybe 4 or 8 bars. Common outros include letting the reverb tails ring out, filtering everything down to low or high, or reintroducing the intro pad/vinyl noise to bookend the track. Since wave phonk tracks are great for “night drive” playlists, sometimes producers make the outro DJ-friendly by ending on a clean downbeat or a sustained pad. In FL, you might simply automate a low-pass filter to gradually muffle the master output in the last few bars, simulating a fade into the distance.

- **Transitions & Ear Candy:** Advanced producers pay attention to transitions between these sections. Automation and FX are used to glue sections together. For example, riser samples, impacts, sweepers, and cymbal washes help signal a change. Every 4 or 8 bars, consider adding a subtle fill or effect. A few ideas: reverse a small portion of the cowbell lead as a swoop into a new section; use Gross Beat or tape-stop effect on the master for a split second at transitions; automate a delay feedback to create a trailing echo when muting a part. Polish every transition – this could mean adding a fill at the end of a bar, or even automating a quick reverb swell on a vocal before it cuts off. These little details make the track sound professional and keep the listener engaged through each change.

#### Advanced Production Techniques (Automation, Layering, Modulation)

To achieve a polished wave phonk track, producers employ a host of advanced techniques in FL Studio projects: automation for movement, layering for richness, and modulation for evolving textures.

- **Automation for Dynamic Movement:** Automation is critical in wave phonk to keep the atmospheric elements interesting and to ensure the mix breathes with the beat. Common automations include filter cutoffs, volume fades, and effect wet/dry controls. For instance, automating a low-pass filter cutoff on a pad or sample can gradually introduce brightness. Many intros and breakdowns use a low-pass filter that slowly opens up as the drop approaches (and sometimes closes back down in breakdowns). In FL Studio, you can automate the frequency knob of an EQ band or use Fruity Love Philter for more complex filtering patterns. Volume automation is often used for sidechain effects or creative ducking. While you can sidechain with a compressor, some producers manually draw volume automation curves for precise control. For example, you can link the volume of a pad or lead to an automation clip that ducks on every kick, achieving the pump without a compressor’s coloration. The EDMProd tutorial demonstrates ducking a melody by adding volume automation on each kick/snare to let them cut through. Similarly, automating reverb sends is useful: you might increase reverb on a lead during a break for a huge atmosphere, then automate it down to keep the drop punchy. Don’t shy away from creative automations too: automate panning on a background texture to swirl it around the listener, or automate distortion amount on a bass for a growl effect in certain notes.

- **Layering Sounds for Thickness:** Layering is an

essential technique to get the “thick” and “full” sound characteristic of pro productions. Rather than relying on a single sample or synth for an important element, wave phonk producers layer multiple sounds and then bus them together for processing. For example, layering snares/claps: it’s common to stack a snare with a clap (and even a second snare) to get a snappy yet big snare. One approach is layering a snare for body, a clap for high-end snap, and maybe a reverb-heavy clap for tail – all three hit together . These layers are routed to a single mixer bus (say “Snare Bus”) where they are glued with EQ and saturation . By EQing on the bus, you treat the combined snare sound (e.g. cutting any annoying frequencies or boosting a collective “crack” around 200Hz), and saturation on the bus makes them sound like one unified, gritty snare . Layering synths is also powerful: you might layer a detuned supersaw with a piano or an orchestral pad to get a unique tone for a chord, or layer the iconic cowbell with a subtle high pluck for additional attack. The EDMProd guide layered a synthesized lead from Vital with an actual cowbell sample – blending the two gave a rich lead sound . In FL Studio, you can use the Layer channel to trigger multiple synths with one MIDI, or simply copy the MIDI pattern to multiple channels. Just ensure each layer is tuned and arranged to not clash (e.g., if layering a synth with a cowbell sample, you might low-cut the synth so the cowbell’s punch remains, and let the synth fill in sustain or stereo width). Layering hats: as mentioned, layering a lower, duller hi-hat under a crisp hat can add weight . You could also layer an open hat or shaker with your hi-hat pattern to accent certain hits and provide texture. Whenever you layer, check phase alignment (zoom in on waveforms if audio) and use the Channel Sample Start offset in FL if needed to tighten the transients.

- **Modulation & LFO Effects:** Modulation can bring life to otherwise static sounds. Many wave phonk producers incorporate LFO-based effects for rhythmic or evolving modulation. For instance, applying a rhythmic tremolo or gating effect on pads or leads can create that wavy, pulsing feel. In FL Studio, Gross Beat (Volume envelope presets) or third-party tools like Kickstart/ShaperBox can do this. A tip from EDMProd: they added Cableguys “VolumeShaper” (or the free alternative “STFU”) on the hi-hat bus to add extra groove – essentially an LFO modulating the hat volume to make the pattern more dynamic. You can similarly modulate filter cutoff with an LFO for a wobbling effect on a bass or pad (creating a subtle wah or movement in tone over time). If using synthesizers like Serum, Massive, or Vital, take advantage of internal LFOs to modulate parameters (e.g., automate wavetable position or filter cutoff) – this can produce an evolving Reese bass that wobbles or a lead that subtly changes timbre each bar, adding interest. Envelope modulation is another tool: e.g., set an envelope to slightly pitch down the kick or cowbell at the tail end for a vintage feel, or use FL’s Envelope Controller to dynamically modulate plugin knobs based on audio input. These are advanced moves that can differentiate your sound design.

- **Creative Effects and Sends:** Advanced production often

means setting up effect chains and send tracks for flexibility. For example, instead of putting a huge reverb directly on a lead (which can wash it out), pro producers send the lead to a reverb send channel. In FL, you could use one of the send tracks or just any free mixer track as a dedicated reverb bus: put a big reverb (100% wet) there and send your lead, vocals, or snares to it as needed. This way, you can EQ the reverb return (common to high-cut a reverb so it's not too bright) and even sidechain compress the reverb to the dry signal – a trick to keep things lush but clear. Sidechaining reverb/delay tails to their dry source means the effect is ducked while the source is playing loudly, then swells in the gaps, creating a breathing effect that keeps mixes clean. Another creative effect chain could be parallel distortion: sending a sound to a separate mixer track, distorting it heavily, then blending it under the original for thickness (New York compression style but with distortion). FL's Patcher plugin can facilitate complex parallel chains within one interface if you're comfortable with it.

- **Timing and Groove:** While not a "sound" design in the typical sense, groove is important. Don't quantize everything robotically – a little swing on hi-hats or a slight offset on claps can add human feel. In FL Studio, you can use the global swing slider for the channel rack (which affects patterns with swing enabled) or manually nudge notes in the piano roll off the grid slightly. Some wave phonk beats borrow the triplet or swing feel of southern hip-hop. Experiment with that if it suits the vibe.

In summary, think of automation as painting motion into your track (filters opening, volumes pumping), layering as building a wall of sound (multiple elements forming one powerful voice), and modulation as injecting life (cycles and movements that keep sounds from being static). These techniques, when used tastefully, result in a track that feels professional and engaging from start to finish.

## Mixing and Mastering Approaches

Achieving a polished wave phonk sound requires careful mixing to balance the heavy bass and sharp highs, plus mastering techniques to get that loud, thick "club" sound without losing the wave atmosphere. Here are key mixing and mastering considerations:

- **EQ and Frequency Management:** Given the dense low-end (808s/reese) and lush highs (hats, synths), EQ is crucial to prevent mud. High-pass filtering is your first weapon: roll off low frequencies on nearly every element except your bass and kick. Pads, vocals, hats, cowbell – they usually get a high-pass somewhere in the 100 Hz or higher region to leave room for the 808. For example, phonk vocals are often EQ'd to sound like radio – i.e. no deep bass or ultra highs. Also consider low-pass filtering bright elements that don't need super highs – e.g. low-pass your pads or even snares if you want a darker vibe (LXST's snares often have low-pass and reverb to keep them from being too bright). Use Fruity Parametric EQ2 on each mixer



channel to carve out space: find the “sweet spot” of each sound (boost slightly if needed) and cut away problem areas. Common areas to check: remove muddiness around 200–300Hz in pads if it clashes with vocals, tame harsh 2–5kHz if the cowbell or lead is piercing, and add a gentle high-shelf boost on hats if you need more “air”. Mid/Side EQ can be an advanced technique: for example, use a mid/side EQ (like FabFilter Pro-Q in mid/side mode, or Fruity EQ2’s mid/side options) to make your pads or reverb more stereo – cut a bit of mid (center) highs and maybe boost side highs to widen the ambience, while keeping important stuff (kick, bass, vocal) strong in the mid channel (center of mix).

- **Dynamic Control – Compression and Clipping:** Phonk, especially drift/wave phonk, is known for its heavily compressed, sometimes clipped sound. Compression is used to glue layers and control transients. Drum buses (kicks/snare) might get a bit of bus compression to make them hit as one. More uniquely, wave phonk producers often use multiband upwards compression like OTT to shape tone – for instance, applying OTT on a hi-hat bus to accentuate the highs and squash the dynamics, yielding that consistently present high-end tick. However, caution: too much OTT can make things harsh; dial the depth to 30–50% or EQ after it. On the mix bus or group buses, a soft clipper or wave shaper often catches peaks. In FL Studio, Fruity Soft Clipper on the master can add loudness by shaving off peaks gently. Even more aggressively, some producers will drive sounds into Fruity WaveShaper themselves for creative clipping (the philosophy of “distortion is king” in phonk). Distorting not just 808s but also entire buses is a technique: adding a bit of saturation or distortion on buses (like the hi-hat bus, lead bus, etc.) can glue those elements and add character. For example, you might insert Soundtoys Decapitator or a stock distortion on your lead bus to dirty up all the layered leads slightly, giving them a cohesive grit. As EDMProd notes, applying a “healthy dose of distortion on every bus” (hats, percussion, leads, vocals, etc.) is a way to cohesively “dirty up” the mix and achieve that phonk “low-quality” aesthetic. This doesn’t mean fully destroying the audio – just a touch to each group can tie the mix together. **Clipping and Limiting:** During mastering (or even mix stage), wave phonk doesn’t shy from clipping. Many producers push their mix into a brickwall limiter or clipper to reach competitive loudness. You can use Fruity Limiter in limiter mode or Maximus on the master to hard limit. Ensure your kick and snare transient still poke through – sometimes a slight pre-clipping EQ to tame an overly spiky transient can help the limiter work less. Aim for a loud master, but also remember Sage’s note: the genre isn’t only about loudness; atmosphere matters too. So find a balance where it’s loud and clear.

- **Sidechain Compression (Duck for Clarity):** Perhaps the most important mixing technique in this genre is sidechain compression (ducking other elements when the kick hits). With huge 808s, pads, and leads all playing, the mix would be a muddy soup without sidechaining. By ducking the volume of bass, pads, leads, and even vocals on each kick (and often snare), you create space for the drum

transient and a nice pumping effect. In FL Studio, a classic method is using Fruity Limiter on a target channel, sidechaining the kick to it, and lowering the threshold to compress when kick comes . This works well for bass ducks. Another method is using volume automation or Gross Beat (sidechain preset) for a more predictable shape. The main idea: make sure the kick and snare cut through by ducking other stuff when they hit . Common sidechain targets: Bass (808/reese) should duck heavily to the kick (or even to both kick and snare); Pads and sustained sounds should duck to the kick and snare moderately; Leads/ vocals usually duck slightly to the kick/snare. If you have a four-on-the-floor section, sidechain can be like a house track pump on every beat. In half-time trap sections, you might duck on kick and snare (or kick only, depending on how you want the snare to hit). The result should be that when the kick hits, you feel everything else pull away for a moment – this not only clarifies the impact but also adds that breathing groove characteristic of phonk. Don't overdo the release time; you want the ducking to recover in time for the next beat without wobbling the rhythm (a typical clear sidechain curve is a quick dip and release synced to song tempo). As a reference, producers ensure "most elements should be ducking when the kick and snare hit" – this prevents the mix from turning into one big mush of sound.

- Stereo Imaging: Wave phonk often has a wide stereo image due to its atmospheric pads and FX, but the low-end remains centered. Best practice is to keep your sub and kick mono or center-focused. In FL, you can use the Stereo Separation knob on the 808 track to ensure it's merged to mono (or use effects like Fruity Stereo Shaper to collapse lows). For other elements, create contrast: leads can be slightly stereo (e.g., pan layered leads left/right or use unison), hats and percussion can be panned or stereo-spread (try the Stereo Enhancer plugin lightly on hats or just pan different percussion sounds differently to avoid everything mono). One trick from EDMProd for width: layering an extra clap and high-passing it and stereo-widening it to add width to your snare/clap without muddying low frequencies . This way the "crack" of the snare is central, but a airy tail of a clap gives a stereo breadth. Use mid/side processing in mastering if needed: for example, slightly widen high frequencies in mastering (many mastering suites like Ozone allow a stereo widening on high band) to give the mix that expansive feel, while keeping low frequencies narrow. However, be cautious of phase issues – always check your mix in mono (FL's Wave Candy or Fruity Stereo Shaper can help sum to mono to test) to ensure you haven't lost essential elements.

- Reverb/Delay Management: With huge reverbs in play, manage them so they don't overwhelm. A common mix approach is to EQ reverb returns – cut out lows from reverbs (e.g., everything below 200Hz) so that the reverb doesn't add rumble. Also, sometimes sidechain the reverb tail to the dry signal (especially on vocals or leads) – so when the vocal/lead plays, the reverb ducks, and when there's a gap, the reverb fills in. This keeps intelligibility. FL's Peak Controller can be used: link it inverted to the reverb wet level,

using the dry signal peak as trigger. Similarly, with delays (like an echo on the cowbell), filter the delay repeats (Fruity Delay 3 has built-in high-cut/low-cut controls) to avoid the delays cluttering the mix.

- **Mastering for Loudness and Glue:** Wave phonk tracks are often mastered LOUD (to stand up next to commercial trap and EDM tracks). Achieving loudness often involves clipping as mentioned, and a limiter at the end. A typical mastering chain might be: slight EQ touch-ups (if needed), a multiband compressor or maximizer (to glue frequency bands), a saturator/clipper, and a final limiter. For example, some producers use FabFilter Pro-L or Ozone Maximizer to push the track to around -7 to -5 LUFS (integrated loudness) which is quite hot. The EDMProd guide explicitly says “don’t be scared to go overboard... Phonk is about pushing things beyond a reasonable limit” in terms of loudness and distortion. Of course, monitor for distortion – if your master is audibly crackling or your kick completely disappears under the limiter, back off a bit. A good technique is reference a track: import a reference wave phonk track you admire into your FL project and level-match it. Compare frequency balance and punch. This will tell you if your mix is too muddy or not loud enough in certain bands. Many top producers always A/B with references to ensure their mix and master are on par.

- **“Low-Quality” Aesthetic vs. Clarity:** One interesting aspect of mixing wave phonk is balancing the deliberate lo-fi character with a clean mix. As noted, phonk purposely has a bit of a “degraded” sound (vinyl noise, distortion, etc.), but you still want each element to be distinguishable. The mantra could be: make it dirty, but make sure everything can be heard. So apply distortion and filtering to get that retro grit, but use the above techniques (EQ cuts, sidechaining, stereo separation) to ensure it’s not a wall of mud. It’s a fine line – for example, you might distort your whole drum bus for crunch, but then you might also transient shape or EQ to re-emphasize the snare snap so it doesn’t get lost. Or you’ll filter your pad heavily so it’s lo-fi, but then automate the filter open a bit when the cowbell is not playing, so the pad shines for a moment. Listen in context: continuously toggle effects on/off to see if they’re helping or hurting clarity.

Finally, use your ears and monitors/headphones you trust. After doing a solid mix, a common mastering step is simply to apply a brickwall limiter or clip to hit the target loudness. Phonk often ends up with some degree of master bus clipping (which is acceptable in this genre – some distortion on the master can even add to the vibe). Just ensure it’s musical distortion and not painful. By the end, the track should hit hard, pump nicely with the beat, and envelop the listener in a wide, dark atmosphere – hallmarks of a polished wave phonk production.

### Common Plugins and Tools (Stock & Third-Party)

Sound design and mixing in wave phonk rely on a mix of FL Studio’s

stock plugins and popular third-party tools. Here's a list of plugins frequently used for this genre, and what they're used for:

- Synth Plugins (for Leads/Pads/Bass):
  - FL Stock: Sytrus (FM synth great for reese basses and ethereal pads), Harmor (powerful for detailed sound design, resynthesis of vocals for atmospheric bits), 3xOSC (simple but effective for basic detuned leads like the cowbell-ish tones).
  - Third-Party: Vital (free wavetable synth, highly recommended and used in phonk tutorials , great for designing phonk leads and bass wobbles), Xfer Serum (wavetable synth, common for wave/hardwave producers for supersaws and sharp leads), Sylenth1 or Spire (for trancey leads or pads if going for that Skeler-trance influence). Many wave phonk producers create rich Reese basses with Serum or Vital using detuned oscillators and filtering . Tip: Sage even released a "Wavephonk Essentials" pack likely containing Vital or Serum presets, which implies those synths are standard in this scene.
  - Sampler & Audio Tools: FL's Channel Sampler is typically used to load one-shot cowbells, 808s, and vocals. Edison (FL's audio editor) can be used to record and chop vocal samples or apply noise removal if needed on lo-fi samples. Slicex can be handy if you have a longer vocal you want to chop into phrase slices and trigger rhythmically.
  - Distortion & Saturation:
    - FL Stock: Fruity Wave Shaper is a go-to for distortion (highly flexible for shaping the distortion curve; ideal for crafting hard clipping on 808s or even warming up synths) . Fruity Fast Dist and Blood Overdrive are simpler stock distortions that can add crunch – Fast Dist is brutal (good for extreme dirt on a send maybe), Blood Overdrive adds analog-esque saturation and a bass boost (nice on mid-bass). Maximus can also act as a saturator if you push its bands into compression.
    - Third-Party: Soundtoys Decapitator is a popular saturation plugin for phonk (EDMProd's favorite for "dirtying up" sounds ), offering analog-style drive with tone control. CamelPhat 3 (an older multi-fx plugin, now free/abandonware) is cited as a free alternative to Decapitator – it has distortion, compression, filtering; phonk producers use it to beef up bass and more. RC-20 Retro Color is beloved for lo-fi texture – its distortion, wobble, and bitcrush can make synths and samples sound vintage (e.g., add "RC-20 distortion" on a synth lead as noted in LXST's sound ). Even FabFilter Saturn (versatile saturator) or Plugin Alliance saturators (like Black Box) can be used if available, but the stock options often suffice given phonk's willingness to use harsher distortion.
  - EQ and Filtering:
    - FL Stock: Fruity Parametric EQ 2 is the workhorse for surgical EQ and filtering. Use its steep band-pass to create telephone vocal EQs , or low-pass automation on pads. Fruity Love Philter is a powerful filtering plugin that can create gated filter patterns or filter automations across an 8-slot envelope grid – advanced users might use this for rhythmic filtering effects or even sidechain-like

volume patterns with the right filter shape.

- Third-Party: FabFilter Pro-Q3 (for those who have it) is common for its precision and dynamic EQ features (helpful to tame resonances dynamically). But one can mix wave phonk entirely with stock EQs. iZotope Vinyl (free) isn't an EQ per se, but a vinyl simulation – great for filtering (it has an adjustable year setting that basically low-passes to emulate old speakers) and adding mechanical noise – used on intros and certain samples for instant old-school vibe .

- Reverb and Delay:

- FL Stock: Fruity Reverb 2 does a decent job for basic big halls and plates (increase size and decay for those cavernous vocal reverbs). Fruity Convolver can be used with impulse responses if you want unique spaces (like a specific hall IR for a huge pad wash). Fruity Delay 3 is very powerful – it can do synced delays, ping-pong, plus has built-in distortion and modulation. Use it for creating those tailing echoes on cowbell leads or vocals. It's often good to modulate delay time slightly for a tape echo feel.

- Third-Party: Valhalla VintageVerb or Room are popular for lush, dense reverb tails on pads and leads. FabFilter Pro-R if precision is needed. But an interesting one is ArtsAcoustic Reverb which some trap producers used historically for its huge hall sound – any reverb that can do a 4–8 second decay smoothly can work for wavey pads. For delay, EchoBoy (Soundtoys) is a go-to for many producers due to its analog flavor and saturation on echoes.

- Compression and Dynamics:

- FL Stock: Fruity Limiter (in compressor mode) can be used for sidechaining duties or general compression, though its interface is a bit clunky for detailed work. Fruity Compressor or Fruity Multiband Compressor (or Maximus for multi-band) can handle standard glue tasks (Maximus is actually quite powerful – you can set it up like an OTT by heavily compressing highs and lows separately). Gross Beat isn't a compressor, but note that its gating patterns can substitute sidechain compression with the right volume envelope shape.

- Third-Party: Xfer OTT (free) – practically a staple for phonk on drums/hats or even master bus for that bright, compressed sound . It's essentially a multiband compressor preset that's become a genre sound in itself. FabFilter Pro-C2 if precise compression needed (for example, sidechaining with lookahead to catch transients). VolumeShaper by Cableguys (or Kickstart by Nicky Romero) – these are popular for quick sidechain-style ducking without actual compression, used in EDM a lot and applicable to phonk as well for the pumping effect.

- Sidechain & Modulation Tools: In FL, Fruity Peak Controller can be used to create custom sidechain links (advanced but useful if you want to duck multiple targets with one trigger in a flexible way). Fruity Balance (with automation clip) is a simple volume automation approach. Gross Beat (sidechain presets or your own volume envelope shapes) is extremely quick for that rhythmic ducking – many FL users prefer Gross Beat for consistent sidechain shape (e.g.

the 1/2 beat gate pattern). Third-party, as mentioned, ShaperBox's VolumeShaper or the free MeldaProduction MAutopan (in volume mode) can do similar volume modulation. LFO Tool by Xfer is another alternative for sidechain and trance-gate effects .

- Stereo Imaging and Utility:
- FL Stock: Fruity Stereo Shaper (for advanced mid/side routing or Haas effect delays), Stereo Enhancer (simple tool to widen or narrow, basically mid/side gain tool – can be used on hats or pads to widen). Panning controls per channel and in Piano Roll (use the pan automation per note for creative stereo on hats or percs).

- Third-Party: Izotope Ozone Imager (free) – quick way to widen certain stems or even master (with care). Brainworx Control or S1 Imager for mid/side adjustments if needed. Generally, stereo imaging should be done subtly; these tools help check and adjust width.

- Special Effects:
- Little AlterBoy (Soundtoys) – specifically mentioned for pitching/formant shifting vocals . Great for creating those low/high octave vocal layers easily. If not available, FL's NewTone or Pitcher or even Elastic Pitch in playlist can do formant shifts.

- Gross Beat / Time Manipulation: Gross Beat can also do tape-stop effects or stutter effects – might be used creatively in fills (like chopping a bar with a stutter or slow-down before a drop).

- Fruity Slicer / Glitch: Some wave phonk producers might incorporate glitchy elements. FL's Gross Beat (glitch presets) or dBlue Glitch VST (free) can create stutter/reverse effects that, if used sparsely, add interest (for example, stuttering the cowbell for a beat or reversing a vocal chop momentarily).

- Visual Analyzers: Not a sound, but to refine your mix, FL's Wave Candy (spectrum or oscilloscope) and SPAN (Voxengo) (free spectrum) can help identify frequency build-ups or sub level. Some producers use Wave Candy in oscilloscope mode to ensure their kick+808 waveform is looking clean (especially since phonk often involves clipping; you want to see a nice flat-top wave but with clear transient separation).

In summary, FL Studio's stock suite covers almost everything needed: Parametric EQ2, WaveShaper, Reeverb 2, Delay 3, Limiter, Maximus, Gross Beat, Stereo Shaper – these will be your daily drivers. Third-party plugins like Vital (synth), Decapitator/OTT (distortion/compression), RC-20/Vinyl (lo-fi), AlterBoy (vocal tweak), and Kickstart/LFO Tool (sidechain) are commonly referenced in the wave phonk community , but there's usually a stock or free alternative for each if you don't have them. The key is less about which exact plugin, and more about how you use them – e.g. heavy distortion, heavy reverb, smart EQ carving, etc., can be achieved with various tools.

### Example Effects Chains from Top Producers

To further illustrate, here are some advanced effects chains and

processing techniques used by leading wave phonk producers on key elements of their mix:

- Distorted 808 Bass Chain: 808 Sample or synth → Fruity Wave Shaper (drive the curve for saturation) → Fruity Limiter (set to limit mode, ceiling just at 0dB to hard-clip peaks) . This combo creates a loud, gritty 808 with a flat-top waveform (hard clip). After that, an optional EQ to cut sub-bass flab below ~30Hz and shape the tone (sometimes a dip around 200Hz if too boomy). Some producers then add OTT at 30-50% mix to accentuate the harmonics from the distortion . The result is an 808 that hits like a truck and sustains with distortion tail. (Make sure to sidechain this to the kick if the kick is separate, or if the 808 is your kick, sidechain other elements to it.)

- Gritty Lead (Cowbell/Synth) Chain: Cowbell sample (punched up with a transient if needed) + layered Synth Lead (e.g. Vital patch) → EQ (to slot each layer, e.g. cut some mids from cowbell if synth fills that, cut highs from synth if cowbell provides it) → Bus those layers together → on the Lead bus: Distortion (e.g. Soundtoys Decapitator or Fruity Blood Overdrive at low drive for warmth) → Delay (1/4 note ping-pong delay, low-passed feedback for ambience) → Reverb (medium-large hall, 20-30% wet). This chain gives a lead both grit and space. For example, LXST CXNTURY's distorted synth melodies could be achieved by saturating the synth, and adding delay/reverb so it rings out into the atmosphere . Finally, apply sidechain on this lead bus tied to kick/snare so that the delays and sustains duck appropriately and don't cloud the mix .

- "Memphis" Vocal Chain: Vocal sample → Pitch/Formant shift (Little AlterBoy to drop an octave and/or raise formant for eerie tone; for multiple layers, create one +12 semitones, one -12, etc.) → EQ (high-pass ~150Hz, low-pass ~8kHz for "telephone" effect) → Distortion/Bitcrusher (e.g. camelCrusher or stock Waveshaper, just a touch to grain-ify the sound) → Reverb (decay ~2-3s, fairly wet to smear the vocal) → Compressor (to flatten dynamics since we want it tucked in consistently) → Stereo (mono-ize the low frequencies or entire vocal if it has stereo info, since old samples might be stereo noise – making it mono makes it sit center) . Finally, sidechain the vocal to the kick (and possibly snare) so it ducks slightly on drum hits . The end result should be a ghostly, barely intelligible vocal that adds vibe but never overpowers the beat.

- Snare/Clap Bus Processing: Snare sample + clap layer (and maybe a perc) routed to a "Snare Bus" → Fruity Parametric EQ2 (tone shaping: e.g. cut harsh 4k or boost 200Hz "chest" if needed) → Fruity Wave Shaper or Soft Clipper (drive a bit for smack; clipping the snare a bit can make it louder in the mix) → Reverb (send) (often instead of inserting reverb directly, send a portion of snare to a reverb bus for that tail; producers will use a short plate or a boomy room reverb depending on desired sound – phonk often has a noticeable reverb on snare). In EDMProd's example, they layered snares/claps and applied EQ and saturation on the bus , and even added an extra wide clap layer high-passed for width . You can follow that: have one clap

layer 100% panned left/right, high-passed to remove body, so it just adds width to snare hits. Ensure the snare bus is hitting about as loud as the kick for balance (the clipper will help catch peaks so you can push it).

- **Hi-Hat Bus Processing:** All hi-hats and shakers → route to Hat Bus → EQ (high-pass ~200Hz to kill low junk, maybe a small mid cut if too sharp) → OTT (multiband compress to even out and brighten hats) → Saturation (a light tape saturation to soften the digital highs a tad and add consistency) → (Optional) Transient shaper (to tame or add attack depending on hat style – if hats are too clicky, soften; if not cutting, add attack). As a creative touch, apply a Volume LFO (sidechain shape) on the hat bus to give groove – e.g. sidechain hats a tiny bit to the kick, or use a rhythmic gate to syncopate them. EDMProd added a volume modulation (with an LFO Tool alternative) to hats for extra movement. This can simulate a drummer's feel or just add a pulse to the high-end.

- **Pad / Atmosphere Chain:** Pad sound (could be a synth pad or even a background sample like wind) → Chorus/Dimension Expander (to stereo widen and thicken – Fruity Chorus or a Dimension expander effect) → Reverb (big hall, long decay, very wet – aim for a washy tail that fills space) → EQ (low cut to ~150Hz, maybe dip 300–500Hz if too murky, and often low-pass a bit to avoid it dominating the highs). Then set up a sidechain ducking either via Fruity Limiter or Gross Beat to duck the pad on each kick. This way the pad swells in the gaps of the beat, giving that classic wave “waveform” motion. If the pad is tonal and clashes with the cowbell, consider an automated filter: e.g. pad is low-passed more during the cowbell sections, and opens up in breakdowns when the cowbell is out, as one Redditor implied – “piano with low pass... pad in background... simple melodies, not making jazz”. This chain ensures your pad adds depth without muddying the drop.

- **Master Bus Chain:** While specifics vary, a possible master chain: Fruity EQ2 (tiny cuts or a slight high-shelf boost if mix is dull), Maximus (set to a gentle compression on bands or even just use its preset like “Saturate” to soft clip – you can multi-band compress a bit for glue), Fruity Soft Clipper or WaveShaper (set threshold so occasional peaks hit it – adds loudness), Limiter/Maximizer (ceiling at -0.1dB, push input until you reach desired loudness). Many mastering processes for phonk will also consider a touch of stereo widening on the sides in the high frequencies (but careful not to widen bass). The final limiter is often working hard – phonk tracks can afford some distortion from limiting. Remember to compare with references: if your track is less loud, you can probably push more. If it's loud but drums lost punch, ease off a dB or two and call it done. The goal is a track that bangs on car speakers and club systems, with the bass loud and the high end present. Using a reference track in your DAW can help you judge this final chain.

Each producer might tweak these chains (for example, Skeler might add trance gate patterns, Sage might focus more on lush reverb tails, etc.), but these examples cover many of the advanced processing tricks



observed in wave phonk production.

## Insights from Notable Wave Phonk Producers

Learning from the best, here are some insights and practices from leading wave phonk artists:

- **Skeler:** Known for pioneering the “hardwave” sound, Skeler often fuses genres. He’s mentioned integrating hardstyle and trance elements into wave – for producers, this could mean using supersaw chords, gated trance plucks, or arpeggiated melodies in phonk tracks to create a fresh festival feel. Skeler’s tracks tend to have very clean mixing despite heavy sounds – likely achieved by strict EQ carving and sidechain. Also, he’s made his tracks more “club friendly,” which translates to ensuring consistent loudness and punch for live play . Emulating Skeler: try layering a trance arp (with sidechain) over a phonk beat, or use a 4-on-the-floor kick pattern in some sections for that festival vibe.

- **SAGE:** Sage emphasizes atmosphere over loudness. In an interview he noted you “don’t have to make the hardest or loudest tracks; it’s more about creating an atmosphere or vibe that emotionally connects” . He also described his style as “atmospheric wave-influenced phonk... something for a late-night drive” . For producers, this is a reminder not to sacrifice vibe for sheer volume – maintain dynamics where needed, and ensure your sound choices serve an emotive purpose. Sage also curated a Wavephonk sample pack, which shows the importance of high-quality sound selection – he and other pros often use well-crafted samples for drums and one-shots (like the SAOL Ascending or Evine drum kits, as fans note ). Good samples = less mixing work.

- **MRJY (MRJay):** MRJay’s wavephonk (listen to “Tokyo 4AM” mixes) is very emotional and melodic. He likely layers a lot of organic textures (rain sounds, city noises) to create a nocturnal vibe. His insight via social media: he identifies as an “emotional bass music producer” , blending wave and phonk. The takeaway is to infuse your own emotion – whether through melody or sample choice (e.g. using a poignant vocal chop). Technically, his tracks still adhere to the heavy bass and crisp percussion formula, so he likely uses similar techniques of distortion and sidechain.

- **Shexpir & ROUDS:** These producers are known for night drive wave/phonk tracks with cinematic quality. While specific interviews are scarce, you can tell from their mixes that they pay attention to detail in layering and stereo field. They probably use a lot of sidechained white noise swells, rise/fall effects and have very tight drum samples. ROUDS tracks often have strong drive and clear kicks – likely using sidechain and transient designers to keep kicks punchy through the mix. Shexpir (who even titled a track “.wav”) has showcased project files where it’s clear he uses automation on virtually everything (volume, filters, reverb sends) to achieve movement (a YouTube project showcase hints at lots of automation clips on his playlist ).

- **LXST CXNTURY:** From the earlier analysis , LXST's style shows that wave phonk isn't one-size-fits-all. He often forgoes 808s for reese bass and uses less cowbell, focusing more on pads and a dark trap feel. His drums are "generic trap style" but the sounds are picked to be phonk-y (lo-fi snares, etc.) . He also layers unusual ambient sounds subtly (like crickets, as noted) . The insight here: feel free to break some phonk conventions – e.g. you don't always need the cowbell blaring; you can use a distorted synth lead instead. You can use a reese bass to fill space rather than the standard 808+gap approach. What matters is the track still feels "phonk" (through the swing, the vocal, the distortion) and "wave" (through the atmosphere).

Across all these producers, a common best practice emerges: sound selection is crucial. Nearly every expert will tell you that picking the right samples and synth presets to begin with makes the process much easier and the end result more professional . Use the drum kits and preset packs available (or craft similar quality sounds) so you're not fighting to fix a weak sound later.

Additionally, critical listening and referencing are habits of the pros. Compare your mix with tracks by Skeler or others – is your bass as powerful? Is your high end as silky or did you go too sharp? They will also test their mixes on different systems (car, headphones) since wave phonk is often enjoyed in cars during night drives – bass translation to car subwoofers is key.

### Best Practices for a Polished Wave Phonk Sound

To wrap up, here is a summary of best practices and actionable tips to achieve a professional-quality wave phonk production in FL Studio:

- **Carve Out Space:** Use EQ proactively – carve lows from non-bass elements , notch out muddy mids, and make sure your kick, 808, and lead each have their own primary frequency zone to shine. Wave phonk mixes can get crowded, so avoid frequency collisions early on.
- **Distort and Saturate (Almost) Everything:** Don't be shy with distortion – apply it on your 808, on your lead, on your drums bus, etc., to get that phonk grit . A bit of drive on each group glues things together and adds presence. Just keep an ear on the cumulative effect; use tone knobs or EQ to tame any unpleasant artifacts from heavy distortion.
- **Pump with Sidechain:** Make sidechain compression your friend. The heavy pump not only clears the mix but also contributes to the genre's vibe . Sidechain the bass, pads, and often leads to the kick (and snare) – get that nice "ducking" groove. If using Gross Beat or automation for sidechain, ensure the curve is smooth to avoid clicks and the timing is musical (usually synced to kick rhythm).
- **Layer with Purpose:** Layer sounds to enhance, not to clutter. For every layer you add (be it a second synth, an added percussion, etc.), have a purpose: e.g., "I'm adding this clap layer

purely to widen the snare” or “I’m layering a sub under my reese to reinforce sub-30Hz”. After layering, bus and process them together so they act as one.

- **Use Automation to Evolve:** Avoid static sections. Automate filters, reverb sends, pan, etc., to ensure that even if a section repeats, something is moving or changing. This can be subtle (like an EQ slowly brightening a pad) or drastic (tape-stop effect into a drop). This keeps the listener engaged subconsciously.
- **Check Mono Compatibility:** Because of the heavy stereo effects, always check your mix in mono. Make sure the lead or vocal doesn’t vanish when summed. Use Stereo Shaper’s mono preset or just collapse your master to mono temporarily. Ensure kick and bass are punchy in mono (they should be if centered). This practice catches any severe phase issues early.
- **Keep It Atmospherically Cohesive:** All your reverb and ambient elements together create the “space” of your track. Decide on a general ambience – is it a huge hall or a dark room? – and try to make your reverbs complement each other. For example, you might use a big hall reverb as a send for most melodic elements to simulate them being in one big space together. This cohesion makes the track sound like a coherent “world” of sound.
- **Loudness and Mastering:** Push your track loud, but smartly. Use clipping to your advantage – many phonk producers intentionally clip the master a bit for loudness and character. Just avoid obvious crackles; a soft clipper can often increase loudness transparently up to a point. After mastering, compare with commercial wave phonk tracks – if yours is quieter, you might be able to limit a bit more. If yours is as loud but sounds more distorted than music, you might need to ease off or improve the mix balance. Referencing is key.
- **Final Polish:** Spend time on the details in the last 5% of production. This means fine-tuning volume balances (is the cowbell 0.5 dB too loud? is the reverb tail ringing a hair too long?), cleaning up any clicks or pops, automating mutes or FX for any stale moments, and ensuring each 8-bar section has some small “ear candy” (a new percussion fill, a different vocal chop, etc.). These subtle touches – a reverse leading into a snare here, a slight pitch bend on the last cowbell note there – make a big difference in perceived professionalism.
- **Keep the Vibe:** Amidst all the technical tweaking, remember the core vibe. Wave phonk should transport the listener – whether it’s a late-night drive feel, an adrenaline pumping drift scene, or an emotive wave journey. If a mix decision cleans something but kills the vibe, find a compromise. Sometimes a bit of muddiness or “wrongness” is actually part of the character (like the detuned cowbell itself – technically dissonant, but that’s the style). So polish the track, but don’t sterilize it. As Sage implied, vibe is king, not just loudness.

By following these practices – focusing on strong sound sources, using

advanced processing creatively, and constantly refining the mix – you'll be equipped to create wave phonk tracks that stand toe-to-toe with the works of Skeler, Sage, MRJay, Shexpir, ROUDS, and other top producers. In FL Studio, all the tools are at your disposal for cutting-edge sound design (from Fruity WaveShaper for distortion to automation clips for every parameter). Combine that with the genre-specific techniques (detuned cowbell leads, sidechained 808s, lo-fi vocal chops, etc.) and you'll achieve that polished, professional wave phonk sound: atmospheric, hard-hitting, and irresistibly phonky.